Wei(Rocio) Zhong

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Academic Appointments

Stony Brook University, Stony Brook, NY
Department of Political Science

Assistant Professor, Sep 2025 – Present

New York University, New York, NY
Center for Social Media, AI, and Politics

Postdoctoral Research Scientist, Sep 2023 – Aug 2025

George Washington University, Washington, DC
Institute for Data, Democracy & Politics, School of Engineering and Applied Science

Research Scientist, Feb 2021 – Aug 2023

Affiliated Faculty

Stony Brook University, Stony Brook, NY
Institute for Advanced Computational Science (IACS)

New York University, New York, NY
Center for Social Media, AI, and Politics (CSMaP)

George Washington University, Washington, DC
School of Engineering and Applied Science

Education

University of Illinois at Urbana-Champaign, Urbana, IL

Ph.D., Political Science, Aug 2021

Dissertation: "Candidates, the Economy and Voting Behavior"

M.S., Statistics, May 2018

New York University, New York, NY

M.A., Politics, May 2014

University of International Business and Economics, Beijing, China

B.A., Spanish, Jun 2009

Research Interest

Comparative Politics, Political Methodology
Online Hate and Extremism, Polarization, Social Media, Computational Methods

Publications

Zhong, W., & Broniatowski, D.A. (2023). Economic risk framing increases intention to vaccinate among Republican COVID-19 vaccine refusers. *Social Science & Medicine*, 317, 115594.

Bailard, C., Tromble, R., **Zhong, W.**, Bianchi, F., Hosseini, P., & Broniatowski, D.A. (2024). "Keep Your Heads Held High Boys!": Examining the Relationship between the Proud Boys' Online Discourse and Offline Activities. *American Political Science Review*, 1–18.

Zhong, W., Bailard, C., Broniatowski, D., & Tromble, R. (2024). Proud Boys on Telegram. *Journal of Quantitative Description: Digital Media*, 4, 1–47.

Zhong, W., & Zhang, M. (2025). Subdued but Unbroken: The Cohesion of Far-Right Extremist Followers after Deplatforming. *Perspectives on Politics*, 1-26.

Lukito, J., Macdonald, M., Chen, B., Brown, M.A., Prochaska, S., Yang, Y., Greenfield, J., Suk, J., **Zhong, W.**, Dahlke, R., & Borah, P. (2025). Candidates Be Posting: Multi-Platform Strategies and Partisan Preferences in the 2022 US Midterm Elections. *Social Media+ Society*, 11(2).

Zhong, W., Chen, B., Liang, F. & Zhang, M. (2025). Picturing Protest: A Deep Dive into the Visual Representation of Protests in Authoritarian Countries' Media on Twitter. *Digital Journalism*, 1-22

Broniatowski, D., **Zhong, W.**, W., Simons, J.R., Jamison, A.M., Dredze, M., & Abroms, L.C. (2025). Explaining Twitter's inability to effectively moderate content during the COVID-19 pandemic. *Scientific Reports*, 15(1), 36096.

Lukito, J., Pruden, M. L., Suk, J., Yang, Y., & **Zhong, W.** (2026). Political Communication Special Issue Introduction: Multi-Platform Research. *Political Communication*, 43(2), 175–191.

Lukito, J., Zhang, Y., Chen, B., Prochaska, S., Pruden, M.L., Yang, Y., **Zhong, W.**, Brown, M., Dahlke, R., Greenfield, J., Suk, J., & Borah, P. (2026). Cross-platformization: How US right-leaning media curate their posts on Twitter and Truth Social. *New Media & Society*, 14614448261470889.

Suk, J.*, **Zhong, W.***, Zhang, Y., Pruden, M., Yang, Y., Mao, C., & DiFranzo, D. (2026). Rethinking Digital Trace Inference in Political Communication: Evidence from a Simulated Platform Experiment. *Journal of Information Technology & Politics*, 1–18. [*co-first author]

Zhong, W. (2026). From Policy to Personality: How Americans Evaluate Presidential Candidates, 1984–2020. *American Politics Research*, 1532673X261492697.

Under Review

Sanderson, Z.*, **Zhong, W.***, & Tucker, J.A. It Works When It Works: Measuring the Direct and Indirect Effects of AI Labels on Political Images. (R&R) [*co-first author]

Zhong, W., Tan, H., Wang, B., & Zhang, K. Self-reinforcing media antagonism sustains U.S.-China rivalry

Zhong, W., Zhang, Y, & Xu, Y. Territorial Contraction: Far-Right Mobilization and Everyday Public Life in American Neighborhoods

Pang, X., Tan, H., **Zhong, W.**, & Zhang, K. The Affective Security Dilemma? Fear and Anger in U.S.-China Relations

Zhong, W. Making Local Action Visible: White Lives Matter on Telegram.

Selected Works in Progress

Bisbee J, & **Zhong, W.** WLM Telegram: Images and Text

Zhong, W., Much, M., Nagler, J., & Tucker, J.A. Tweets and Beliefs: Online Political Environments and Immigration Attitudes

Zhong, W., & Nagler, J. Opinion Change and Voter Learning across Political Issues in U.S. Elections.

Zhong, W., Xu, X., & Chen, H. The Rise and Contestation of Identity in Global Media

Barrie, C., Zhang, M., **Zhong, W.**, Nagler, J., & Tucker, J.A. Social Media and Cross-Cutting Conversations

Grants & Awards

OR&I Seed Grant 2026
Stony Brook University

China and AI Research Award 2026
Paul and Marcia Wythes Center on Contemporary China, Princeton University
(with Xu Xu, Princeton University)

FAHSS Research Grant 2026
Faculty of Arts, Humanities, and Social Sciences, Stony Brook University

FAHSS Travel Grant 2026
Faculty of Arts, Humanities, and Social Sciences, Stony Brook University

Selected Professional Experience

US 2020 Presidential Election Researcher — Dec 2021 - Sep 2023
META (formerly Facebook)
Menlo Park, CA

Data Science Research Intern — May 2019 - Aug 2019
DiDi AI LABS
Beijing, China

Teaching Experience

Instructor

POL 201 Introduction to Statistical Methods in Political Science, SBU	Spring 2026
POL 604 Quantitative Analysis III (Graduate), SBU	Fall 2026, Fall 2025
PS 385 Politics of the European Union (Online), UIUC	Spring 2020
PS 241 Comparative Politics in Developing Nations (Online), UIUC	Fall 2019, Spring 2018

Teaching Assistant

Quantitative Analysis I, II, III (Graduate), UIUC	2018–2019
Introduction to Political Research, UIUC	Spring 2017
Introduction to International Relations, UIUC	Spring 2016

Languages

English(fluent), Chinese(native), Spanish(proficient)

Software

Python, R, SQL, LATEX, Git, ArcGIS

Services

Manuscript Referee
American Political Science Review, Political Behavior, Political Communication, Journal of Experimental Political Science, PNAS Nexus, Nature Communications

Guest Editor
Special Issue on Multi-Platform Research for *Political Communication*